

Paid Data for AMC: A Verified Buy/Skip Review

Which commercial datasets are worth buying for a scrap & coin dealer's research program — every price checked against the vendor's live page, every recommendation adversarially re-verified

Bottom line

Only **two purchases** clear the bar — roughly **\$425-725 in year one**. **Databento** (~\$0-125 one-time, likely free inside signup credits; options add-on ~\$50-300) backfills sixteen years of the one dataset the free program calls paywalled: official daily futures open interest. **Greysheet** (\$299/yr) is the dealer-to-dealer wholesale coin bid/ask benchmark — the side of the coin market the free collectors cannot see. Everything else surveyed is free, deferrable, or a documented skip.

About this review

The companion data-acquisition program specifies five free, start-now collectors; this note asks what money could add. A structured survey (2026-07-12) covered six categories — exchange and futures data, coin and numismatic services, physical-market assessments, macro consensus data, news and sentiment feeds, and options / implied volatility. Every price was read from the vendor's live page that day and classified **verified-on-page**, **reported-secondhand**, or **quote-only** (no public price — expect institutional pricing). Every recommended candidate was then re-verified by an independent adversarial pass that re-fetched the pricing page and attacked the claimed benefit. Two candidates failed that pass and their verdicts were reversed; both are documented below.

Four principles governed the verdicts:

- **Don't pay for what the free collectors already capture** — posted retail premiums, search interest, forward open-interest capture, release calendars, AMC's own ledger.
- **One-time historical purchases are backfillable by definition**. They can be bought whenever a project actually needs them, so the start-now urgency of the collector program does not apply — buy on demonstrated need, unless trivially cheap.
- **The program's own pre-registered null rules out news-sentiment feeds**. Text sentiment features added zero forecasting lift and hurt out-of-sample performance.
- **Small-business budget**. Hundreds to low thousands of dollars a year; enterprise quote-only sales motions are presumptively out.

Buy 1 — Databento: the CME historical backfill (~\$0-125; options ~\$50-300)

Databento resells the official Chicago Mercantile Exchange (CME) market-data feed at usage-based, per-gigabyte prices with no subscription required for historical downloads. Its “statistics” schema carries the exchange's **official daily settlement price, open interest, and volume per instrument** — futures and options strikes — for gold (GC), silver (SI), platinum (PL), and palladium (PA), plus 30-day federal-funds futures (ZQ), back to **June 2010**; the same feed serves 1-minute price bars. New accounts get **\$125 in free credits**, and the portal's cost estimator quotes exact dollars before any purchase, so there is no cost risk. The whole daily backfill plausibly costs nothing;

options-level settlement and open interest per strike add an estimated \$50–300 one-time.

This is the one paid item that converts a wait into a now. The free program's open-interest collector was scoped as “pure seed corn” precisely because history is paywalled — this purchase is that history:

- **Platinum/palladium liquidation-alarm labels today** — the ~38 forced-selling episodes since 2010 become trainable now, not after years of forward accrual.
- **Positioning-nowcast labels** for the same reason.
- **Sharper Fed-surprise measurement** — 1-minute bars around the 2:00 p.m. ET Federal Open Market Committee (FOMC) statement, plus federal-funds futures, upgrade the surprise series behind the hedge playbook from its daily stand-in.
- **Self-computed implied volatility** — from daily option settles, one day of standard option-model code yields at-the-money implied volatility and skew for gold and silver, 2010–2026, a forward-looking benchmark for the spread-floor tail engine and the event-window volatility card. This eliminates any case for enterprise options databases.

Caveats: coverage starts June 2010 (~125 FOMC meetings); pre-2017 data is reconstructed from CME's archival files — spot-check the early years during the free-credit test. License permits internal use, no redistribution. The forward collector still runs regardless; the backfill and the collector meet in the middle.

Buy 2 — Greysheet: the wholesale coin benchmark (\$299/yr)

CDN Publishing's Greysheet is the U.S. coin trade's **dealer-to-dealer wholesale bid/ask benchmark** — the sheet every counterparty quotes against. The “Coin Dealer Digital” tier (\$30/mo or \$299/yr, verified digit-for-digit on the vendor's subscription page) includes twelve digital monthly issues, hourly-updated wholesale values across U.S. coin series plus proof sets, type coins, world bullion gold, and bags; Certified Acceptance Corporation (CAC) values; two users; and basic API (application programming interface) access — heavier API use is metered on top (~\$25/mo minimum).

Verification confirmed this is a genuine gap, not a duplicate: the free premium panel scrapes posted **retail asks**, while nothing free covers the **wholesale bid** — the side AMC actually trades against when exiting inventory. Value arrives on day one with no modelling: are the coin desk's quotes and inventory marks in line with the wholesale market? Skip the Pro tier (\$1,850/yr — a dealer trading network, overkill at AMC's volume), and pay no one else in this category: PCGS and NGC price guides, population reports, and certificate-verification APIs are free, and CAC values arrive inside this subscription. One email worth sending: ask how deep the downloadable historical bid data goes — a deep bid archive would be premium-history gold.

Where verification changed the answer

Norgate Data (\$270/yr — price verified, purchase plan refuted).

Daily settlement, volume, and open interest back to 1978–1982 — the only budget source covering the 1980 silver collapse and the 1997–2001 palladium squeeze. But the surveyed plan (“buy six months, export everything, cancel”) fails the license: all data must be deleted on lapse, so compliant use is a recurring \$270/yr. Revisit only if the liquidation-alarm work demonstrates pre-2010 episodes materially improve it; start with the 2010+ sample.

FXMacroData (\$250–1,000/yr — price verified, benefit refuted).

Advertised point-in-time macro consensus history — exactly the shape needed to extend the Fed event study to inflation-report surprises. Testing the vendor's own free interface showed the historical “consensus” is **retro-generated**: predictions attached to a 2002 announcement carry a 2026 generation timestamp. That is precisely the look-ahead contamination this program's leakage guards exist to catch — a model trained on it would quietly overstate real-time performance. The free alternative: first-print actuals from ALFRED (the St. Louis Fed's real-time archive) plus a scraped consensus column, and the published academic Fed-surprise series. The general lesson: **paid data can carry leakage too** — “point-in-time” is a claim to test, not a label to trust.

CME CVOL implied-volatility history (quote-only — demoted to try-free-first).

CME's official implied-volatility indices for gold, silver, and platinum, up to ~9 years licensable. A free registration may already grant ~2 years of downloads, the silver volatility index relaunched free in 2025, and the Databento options backfill makes self-computed measures the primary source — this becomes a convenience benchmark, worth at most a small one-time quote.

Free sources strong enough to join the collector program

- **Johnson Matthey PGM base prices — including rhodium.** Free CSV downloads, decades of history, verified programmatic pull. Rhodium is typically the dominant value in catalytic-converter scrap and has no exchange price; nothing in the current stack prices it. A strong candidate for a sixth collector, and it makes paid minor-PGM feeds unnecessary.
- **World Gold Council Goldhub India/China local premium series** — free, daily, India from 2012 and China from 2003: a regional physical-demand thermometer for coin-premium work.
- **Cboe GVZ gold implied-volatility index** — free via the existing FRED pipeline, 2008 onward; the silver sibling relaunched in 2025.
- **eBay Terapeak** — realized (not posted) bullion transaction prices, free with a seller account, but a rolling three-year window that ages out permanently: start periodic snapshots of the benchmark products now. WorthPoint (\$30/mo, cancel after) can one-time-backfill realized premiums to ~2006 when that study actually runs.
- **Auction archives** — Heritage (1997+) and Stack's Bowers (2002+) realized prices, free with registration: the cross-check for rarer material walked into the shop.
- **Factiva via university library access** — free, for hand-dating the platinum-group supply events behind the event ledger (manual use only under the license); one month of the mining trade press (~\$11) if paywalls block the sprint.

The skip list

Product class	Representative price	Why skipped
News-sentiment feeds (RavenPack, Dow Jones DNA, budget news APIs)	~\$20–40k/yr; five-figure+; \$30–200/mo	The program's own pre-registered null: sentiment features added zero lift and hurt out-of-sample. Budget APIs also lack archive depth.
Enterprise physical-market assessments (Metals Focus, Fastmarkets, Argus, SFA Oxford, LSEG/GFMS)	\$1,500/report/yr; rest quote-only	Annual-frequency structural data at terminal-lite prices; free substitutes cover it (World Silver Survey, Goldhub, Johnson Matthey's annual report).

Product class	Representative price	Why skipped
Macro consensus / calendars (Trading Economics, Econoday, MNI, Haver, Consensus Economics, Citi surprise index)	\$2,388/yr; rest quote-only or Bloomberg-locked	ALFRED first prints + a scraped consensus column reconstruct surprise series free; official release calendars are already a free collector.
Other futures/options vendors (CME DataMine direct, TickData, Portara, FirstRate, Barchart, OptionMetrics, ORATS)	Portara ~\$1.1-1.65k one-time; Barchart \$200/yr; others quote-only or lack open interest	Dominated by Databento. Portara is the one principled “later”: 1990s intraday if the Fed study ever needs 300+ meetings.
CPM Group yearbooks	\$170/book	Fine one-time references (the PGM volume most differentiated, for rhodium detail); backfillable — buy when a specific table is needed.

Dealer-operations data — flagged for the owner, outside research scope

An adversarial completeness pass asked what a quant survey structurally misses about a dealer. Four finds — real prices, real fit, but business decisions rather than research inputs:

- **Catalytic-converter content databases** (Eco Cat, AutoCatalystMarket; ~\$20-115/mo): serial number → recoverable platinum/palladium/rhodium value, refreshed against current prices — per-piece buy pricing at the counter; arguably the highest operational value per dollar on the scrap side.
- **Jewelers Board of Trade** (\$195/yr): the trade's credit bureau — ratings and bankruptcy alerts on refiners and wholesalers. AMC's metal sits unsecured at counterparties for days-to-weeks; the 2018 Republic Metals bankruptcy burned exactly this class of dealer.
- **Wholesale market-maker feeds** (Dillon Gage FizTrade and peers): live two-way wholesale prices on hundreds of coin and bar products, free-to-nominal with an approved trading account. This is the exit side of the premium — retail and wholesale premia decouple exactly in the stress episodes the premium program targets. If an account exists, logging the feed daily is a non-backfillable series and a natural seventh collector.
- **County probate feeds** (~\$20-150/mo): estates are the canonical origin of coin collections and scrap lots — buy-side deal flow plus a local leading indicator for walk-in supply. Test one county before scaling.

Caveats

- **Prices dated 2026-07-12.** Vendor pricing moves. “Verified-on-page” was read from the vendor's live page that day; “quote-only” means no public price exists — expect institutional pricing.
- **Licensing is part of the price.** Everything recommended was checked for single-business internal research use; none permit redistribution. Norgate's delete-on-lapse term shows a license can void an otherwise correct purchase plan.
- **Paid data can carry leakage.** Any vendor claiming point-in-time history must prove generation timestamps precede the events — the same real-time honesty stamps the free collectors enforce.
- **Nothing here displaces the five collectors.** Purchased history complements forward capture; the single most valuable dataset in the program remains AMC's own ledger, and it costs nothing.

Prepared 2026-07-12 as a companion to the AMC data-acquisition program and the Phase 7 portfolio. Survey and verification: six-category structured review with live web checks; each recommended item independently re-verified the same day. Decision support, not investment advice.